

Practicing Democracy

This is a book about the who, why, and how of democratic practice. It is about learning how we can practice democracy: a pedagogy of democratic practice. Practicing democracy is a craft that can be learned, improved upon, adapted, and sustained. And as a craft it is rooted in decades of practice, research, and teaching students and practitioners in online and offline classrooms, workshops, campaigns, and collaboration with colleagues.¹ Although one writes a book so it can be read, the value of this book can only be realized if it is used to scaffold learning how to work with others.

A pedagogy of practice is at the heart of learning to practice democracy: the way we learn is what we learn, and what we learn is the way we learn.² It is the difference between lessons *about* building relationships and lessons *in* building relationships. When my colleagues and I teach organizing in classrooms, workshops, or campaigns, we structure the learning of each practice in a four-step sequence: explaining, modeling, practicing, and debriefing. Debriefing facilitates the articulation of specific lessons so they stick. It's like learning to ride a bike. Often the first thing that happens when you get on the bike is that you fall off. This is the real moment of truth when you either go home and go to bed, or you find the courage to get back on the bike, knowing that you'll keep falling for a while because it is the only way to learn to keep your balance. In my experience, that's how we learn any practice—including how to practice democracy.

This way of learning requires constructing a holding environment or brave space in which people can respectfully give and receive critical, as well as affirming, feedback, thereby learning with and from each other.³ Participants set their own norms or ground rules to facilitate their learning. These norms usually include practice mutual respect, assume good intent, appreciate impact, and the like. A time norm is especially important: gatherings should begin on time and end on time, and exercises should be completed within the given time frame. This underscores the fact that a person's most precious resource is their time. We can choose to accept responsibility for honoring each person's commitment of their time to learning together. This allows

creation of a space within which everyone—not only the first, the loudest, or the tallest—can learn. It also requires agreement on a norm correction: what a person must do should they show up late. For example, do they sing a song? Do a dance? The point is not public shaming but rather shared responsibility.

Creating a culture of learning is important not only for learning specific practices like storytelling, and not only for enabling real-time improvement of practice in the field, but also because it is required for democracy itself to work.⁴ Democracy can only be sustained if it has created the means for sustained renewal. Each session concludes with takeaways (lessons), pluses (what worked well), and deltas (things that can be improved). This not only models the value of candid evaluation; even more importantly, it builds in continual learning as a sustained—and expected—practice.

We introduced this approach with the launching of the grassroots organization of the 2008 Barack Obama campaign, beginning with a Camp Obama in Burbank in July 2007.⁵ Since then, organizers, trainers, and educators have introduced and adapted this approach for diverse domains throughout the United States, including campaigns for gender equity, immigrant rights, climate change, gun control, economic justice, and politics. Practitioners of health care, education, and union representation have also used this approach in the reform, revitalization, and renewal of their institutions. And globally, local practitioners have adapted it to their use in countries as diverse as Australia, China, Denmark, Japan, Jordan, Kenya, Nepal, Senegal, Serbia, and Sweden.

This is also always a work in progress, needing adaptation, innovation, and continual learning. At the conclusion of my first workshop in Jordan, civic leader, artist, and educator Samar Dudin described our approach as a road map, not a blueprint: how to find the foundations in one's own culture, community, or institution in service of which these practices may be of value. Similarly, this book is an invitation to join us on a learning journey, a never-complete way to enable people to learn, grow, and develop their power to shape their own destinies: the work of democracy.

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Organizing grows out of rich, diverse, and ancient traditions. For some it is rooted in the faith traditions telling the story of a people's arduous journey from slavery to freedom: the exodus story. For others it grows out of a civic tradition, rooted in decisions the Greeks made that they did not need kings

but could govern themselves. People have also found ways to challenge the abuses of power exercised over them, such as the nineteenth-century Irish tenant farmers who held back their produce from their British landlord until he made promised repairs. The landlord's name was Captain Boycott.

Leadership, Organizing, and Action

Leadership: Who, What, and When

Learning organizing begins with learning to practice leadership rooted in three questions posed by Rabbi Hillel, the first-century Jerusalem sage (Figure 1.1). When asked what to do with one's life, Hillel responded with three questions to ask yourself.

If I am not for myself, who will be for me? This is not a *selfish* question. It is a *self-regarding* question. If we are to live—or lead—with integrity, clarity about our own values, resources, interests, and aspirations matters. It can be very hard for us to be fully present to others if we are not fully present to ourselves.

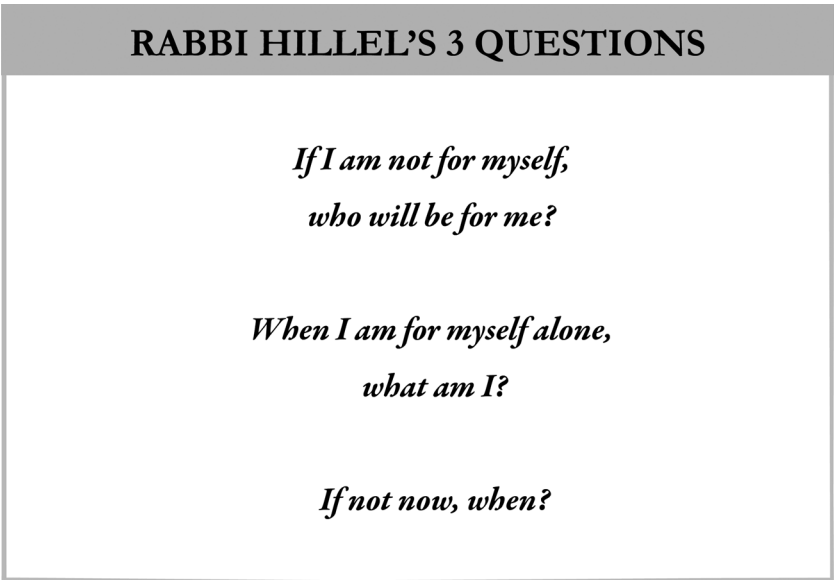


Figure 1.1 Rabbi Hillel's 3 Questions. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

When I am for myself alone, what am I? To be a “who”—a human being—and not a “what”—a thing—is to recognize that we exist in relationship with others. We are relational creatures. And our capacity to realize our own objectives—or even shape them—is inextricably wrapped up with the capacity of others to realize theirs. Alas, most of us have moments in which we are “only for ourselves”—treating others, and even ourselves, as instruments, rather than as ends in ourselves.

If not now, when? This is not advice to jump into moving traffic. Rather, it is a recognition of the fact that we can rarely learn to do well what we hope to do without beginning to do it. It is a caution against what Jane Addams called “the snare of preparation”: we’ll do just another year of strategic planning, we’ll have the perfect plan, so the world will totally conform to our expectations—except that never happens.⁶ The reality is that understanding flows from action, rather than preceding it. And because we cannot know the future, action always entails risk, demanding the courage to take those risks.

Leadership, then, is about the interaction of the self, the other, and the action.

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Why did Hillel respond with questions rather than answers?

What really is the domain of leadership? When things are going well, do we seek out the leadership to thank them? Or do we only ask “who’s in charge here” when we run into problems, challenges, and dilemmas? If the system is working, why do we need leadership?

The reality is that the adaptive capacity of leadership is only of real value in the face of uncertainty, not certainty; the unexpected, not the expected; the challenging, not the routine.

This is what makes leadership itself so challenging.

One way to think about this challenge is in a “hands, head, and heart” way. When confronted by the unexpected, we may ask ourselves, “Do I have the skills to deal with it?” This is a challenge to the hands. We may ask ourselves, “Can I use the resources I have to deal with this new challenge?” This is a strategic challenge, a challenge to the head. When we ask, “How do I find the hope, the courage, the resilience to take risks often required to deal with real change?” or “How do I inspire that hope and courage in others?” we are posing a challenge to the heart. Leadership, then, is a hands, head, and heart practice (Figure 1.2) that I’ve come to define as follows:

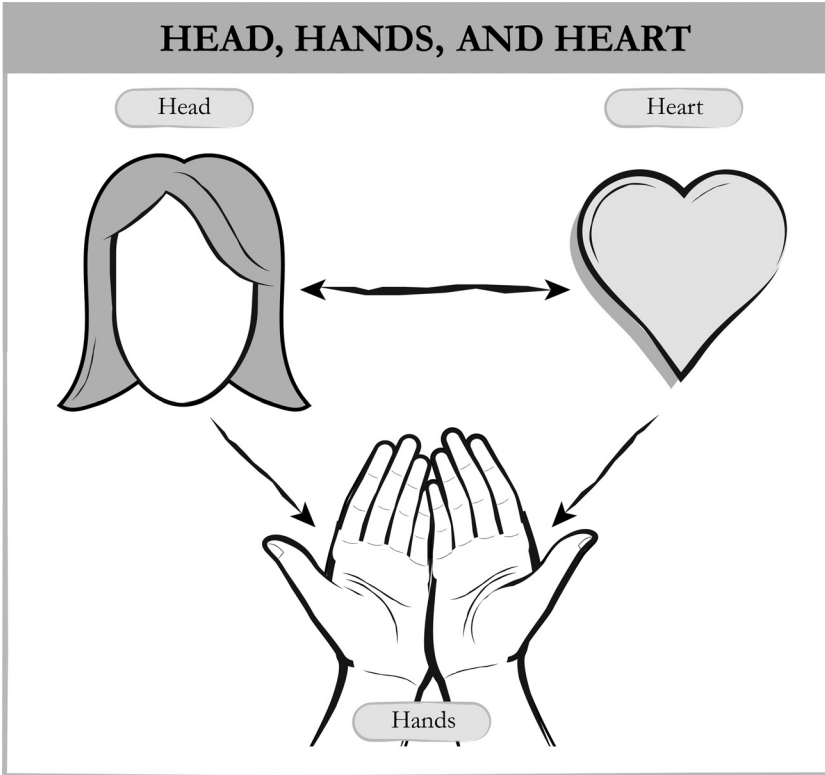


Figure 1.2 Head, Hands, and Heart. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

Leadership is accepting responsibility (self) for enabling others (us) to achieve shared purpose under conditions of uncertainty (now).

Leadership under conditions of uncertainty is therefore more about “learning” than about “knowing.” No one can know the future, so leadership is less about having answers than it is about knowing how to find answers.

Enabling others to mindfully choose action requires entering into a relationship with them, not performing for them. During the massive 2020 protests of the murder of George Floyd—and of racially motivated police violence more broadly—a daily challenge arrived at the doorstep of every mayor. My colleague Sarah ElRaheb-Dagher and I were invited by the Bloomberg Harvard City Leadership Initiative to bring our practice of public narrative to

a cohort of U.S. mayors grappling with this challenge. The greatest challenge these mayors faced in practicing leadership with protesters, the police, and the public was when they tried to fix the problem themselves. They put on a performance, only to find that performance alone couldn't solve the problem. Those who chose a wiser path asked for help, based on their relationships with all the parties, inviting them to become part of the solution rather than a source of the problem.

Finally, leadership is about *practice* rather than *position*. Most of us can easily think of examples of people who occupy positions of formal authority but turn out to be bad leaders. On the other hand, many of us meet people who are practicing leadership in the way I've defined it every day: at kitchen tables, in workplaces, neighborhoods, and elsewhere, without any formal authority, let alone a title, an office, or the CV to go with it.

Organizing: People, Power, and Change

Organizing is a particular form of leadership that asks three further questions:

First, ***who are my people?*** With whom am I entering into a leadership relationship (Figure 1.3)? Notice that the process does not start with identifying an issue. The people involved are both the source of the needed change and the resources that will be used to create that change. We listen, learn, and strategize with our people to identify the issues. Issue-based identities can fragment people; values-based identities can unite people.

Second, ***what change do they want?*** People's hurts and hopes are rooted in their lived experience. What hurts urgently needs healing: too small a check, a school that's failing my child, feeling unsafe in my home, abuse by a spouse, fear of the police? What would look different if we solved this problem: a bigger check (how much?), a better school (in what way?), a safe home (how?). And are these problems—as painful as they are—only symptoms of a deeper problem?

Third, ***how can people work together to turn the resources they have into the power they need to win that change?*** So, what is power? If you need

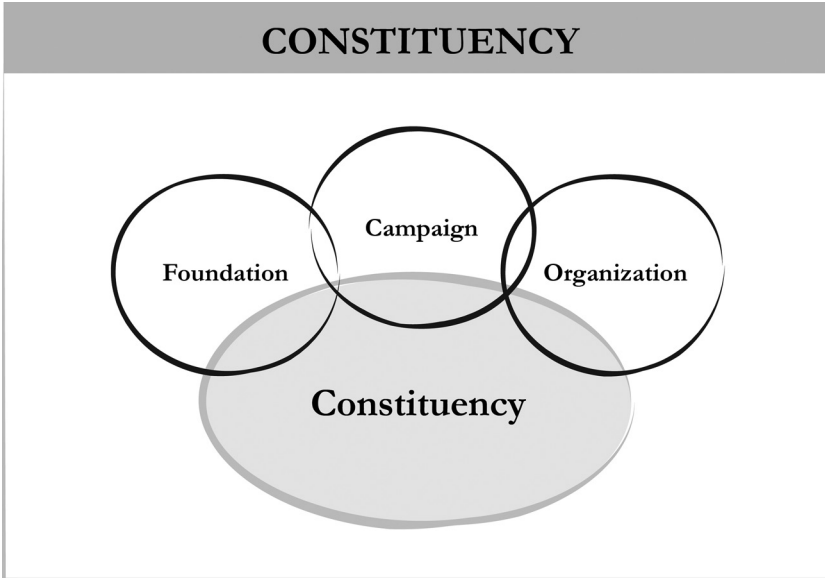


Figure 1.3 Constituency. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

my resources more than I need your resources, who's got the power? I do. And if it is reversed, you do. That's how power works. It's not a thing you possess, but is an interdependent relationship based on the balance of needs and resources (Figure 1.4).⁷

An important distinction between creating power “with” others and exercising power “over” others is rooted in the work of management scholar Mary Parker Follett. If our interests converge and needs and resources are balanced, then we may find that through collaboration, we can create more “power with” each other than by going it alone, such as with a credit union, cooperative, or carpool. But if our interests diverge and I need your resources to meet my needs more than you, at present, need access to mine, I have to figure out how to challenge your “power over” me by learning what needs you have that depend on resources I have (Figure 1.5). In a word, how can I make it more costly for you to resist the change than accept it? A well-known Mexican saying explains why politicians only show up in the barrio before an election: “Al nopal no se

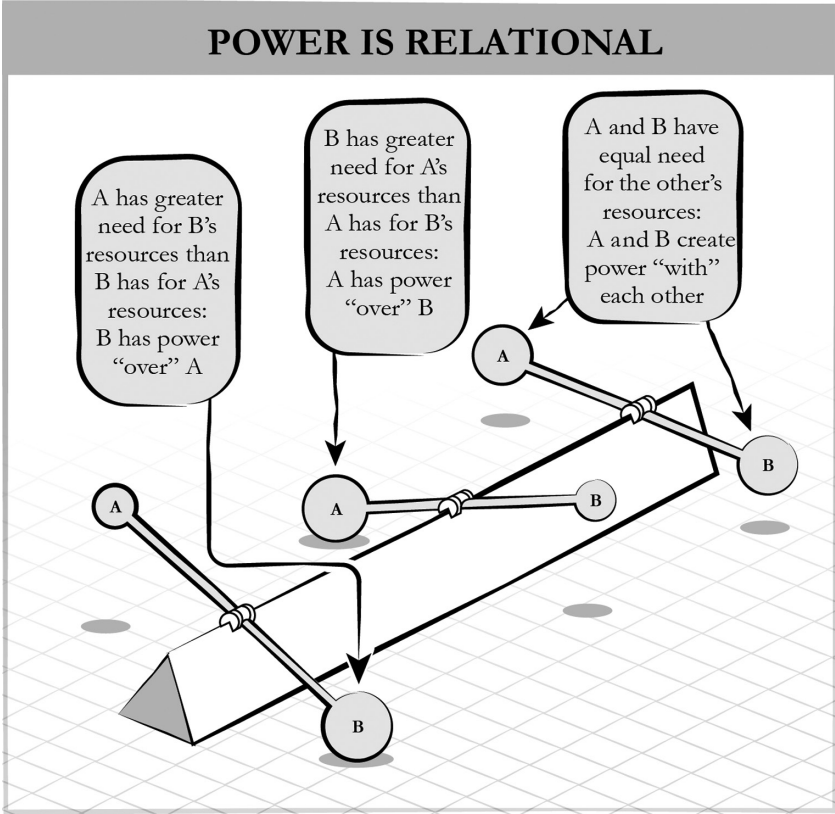


Figure 1.4 Power Is Relational. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

viene a ver, solo cuando tiene tuna” (No one comes to visit the prickly pear except when it’s bearing fruit).

Power also has three faces. The first face is obvious, as when someone gets arrested—we see who won and who lost. But who authorized the arrest, set the rules, enforces them? That’s the second face: who decides. Then we may ask, why has nothing been done about this problem for years, or why do many of us just take for granted that this is the way things are? To figure that out, you must ask who is benefiting and who is losing: the third face. This is when the deep structural contours of power emerge. The strategic organizing challenge is how to engage with the urgent first face—the pain points—but in a way that builds our capacity to take on the third face.

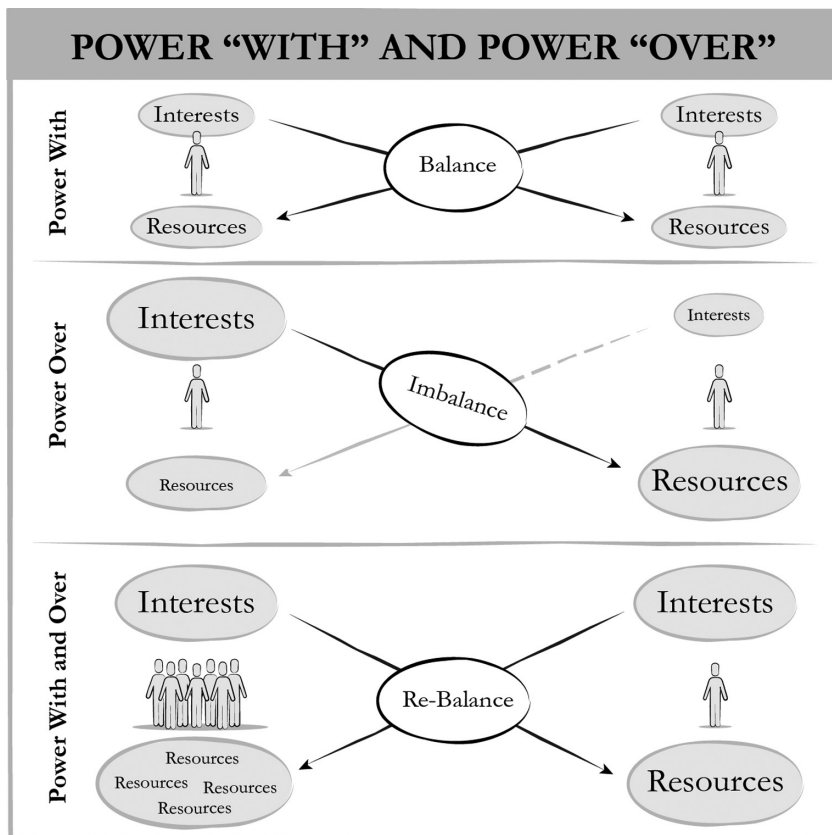


Figure 1.5 Power “With” and Power “Over.” *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

The moral, political, and practical centrality of power in the work of organizing is most compellingly articulated by Pope Francis, in his most recent encyclical, *Fratelli tutti* (All brothers), where he writes,

If one person lacks what is necessary to live with dignity, it is because another person is detaining it. . . .

We are called to love everyone without exception; at the same time, loving an oppressor does not mean allowing him to keep oppressing us, or letting him think that what he does is acceptable. On the contrary, true love

for an oppressor means seeking ways to make him cease his oppression; it means stripping him of a power that he does not know how to use, and that diminishes his own humanity and that of others. . . . Those who suffer injustice have to defend strenuously their own rights and those of their family, precisely because they must preserve the dignity they have received as a loving gift from God.⁸

Organizing is not about providing services to grateful clients. Nor is it about marketing products to paying customers. Organizing is not about advocacy on behalf of powerless beneficiaries. It is about enabling a community to become a *constituency*, from the Latin *con* (together) and *stare* (to stand)—a community that chooses to come together, stand together, learn together, decide together, act together, and in the end win together. It's also what democracy itself is all about.

The impact of an organizing campaign can be evaluated by asking another three questions:

Did we accomplish the goal we set out to accomplish? Did we win the election, pass the law, change the practice, improve the contract?

Did we grow stronger as a constituency than we were when we began?

Did we empower our community, strengthen our organization, grow stronger? Did we learn how to use our resources to shift power held by others into our own hands? If we win a campaign but never want to see anyone involved ever again, our win likely won't stick. Who will get the law enforced, hold the elected accountable, grow stronger for the next round?

The strength of the constituency matters because most of the problems organizers are called on to solve are matters of structural power, not technical inefficiencies. My streets aren't cleaned because of poor sanitation technology. I live in a food desert because of problematic logistics. I can't find affordable housing because there's too much demand. No. These problems persist because something that is a big problem for many is no problem at all for the more powerful few.

Did we recruit, train, and develop the leadership to take our work forward? Did individual participants in the campaign grow, learn, and develop, especially in their leadership? The scale to which an organized movement can grow depends in large measure on the scale of the

committed, skilled, and imaginative leadership it can develop. This is especially so if the movement aspires to make democracy work in neighborhoods, workplaces, schools, cities, states, and the nation.

Action: Hands, Head, and Heart

At the core of organizing are five practices rooted in our daily lives. Each practice is composed of three elements: values (heart), head (concepts), and skills (hands).

The **heart** is a way to describe the domain of emotion, *values* that motivate us and are implicit, if not explicit, in any practice. It is where we go to learn *why* we do what we do. It grounds the *storytelling* that can enable us to access, articulate, and share the motivational resources rooted in our values. It is less about what *is* in the world than about what *is good* in the world.

We use our **heads** to acquire a *conceptual* understanding of *how* to do what we do. Cognitively, it can ground *strategizing* in sustained, systematic, and critical reflection on what we are doing. We can thus improve upon our skills, adapt them to new contexts, and innovate new forms of skill. Conceptual understanding helps us avoid getting stuck in the rote, uncritical, and stagnant actions that only reproduce beliefs that shape the lens through which we discern what *is* in the world.

Our **hands** learn the *skills we need to do what we need to do as action: it is behavioral*. By making explicit how we build relationships, we can bring *craft*, intentionality, and purpose to achieve excellence in our work. We may have to unlearn some of the good-enough ways we built relationships in the past. Action is the place where what we do with our bodies enables learning, communication, and sense-making. I get a radically different and certainly richer understanding of what a strike is by walking on a picket line rather than by reading about it. My understanding of a movement differs if I use my body to join a highly disciplined military march, or if I use it to join an ever-evolving creative protest march. Each of these activities has its own rules, to be sure, but of a very different sort.

Five Practices of Democracy

Organizing is a learnable craft. Each chapter of this book offers a deep exploration of one of what I have identified as the five key practices of organizing (Figure 1.6): building relationships, telling stories, strategizing, acting, and structuring.



Figure 1.6 5 Leadership Practices. Source: Steve Downer of the Difference

Relationship Building

Relationships grow out of the realization of mutual benefit, the creation of shared value, and the commitment to a shared future. They are the threads with which we weave our communities. We all build relationships, some good, some bad, some sustained, some not. Some are with family, some are with friends, some with colleagues, some with collaborators. Different kinds of communities are based on kinship, friendship, neighborhood, schooling, professional identity, the presence, or absence of children, and so on.

Democracy is a political community based on the civic relationships we build with each other. Civic relationships are based on a commitment to the shared purpose, values, norms, and practices of that community and respect for the individuals who constitute that community. Civic relationships, in other words, are a different kind of relationship than those based on kinship, status, wealth, or coercion.

Specifically, it is through civic association with one another that we can learn to turn narrow self-interests into common interests, forge the emotional bonds that enable our solidarity, and develop the skills we need not only to work together but also to govern ourselves. Tocqueville called these forms of association “great free schools of democracy.” The civic relationships

we build with one another, as human beings rather than as data points, are the fabric from which democracy is woven.

The idea of a civic relationship goes back to sixth-century Athens, when the Greeks discovered they could not sustain a *polis* (city) based on equality before the law if individual membership in the polis depended on kinship. They replaced unequal kinship affiliation with equal civic affiliation.⁹ This is the source of the idea that I can be an equal citizen of a city or state without regard to family and, ultimately, to religious belief, gender, race, or national origin.

In our country, this has been more of an aspiration than a reality. Even so, the civic relationships have been eroding as we sort ourselves—or are sorted—into ever-narrowing race-, class-, and status-based enclaves. By learning and re-learning how to initiate, sustain, and renew civic relationships with each other, we can begin to transcend these manufactured enclaves by realizing the real interdependence underlying them, what Martin Luther King Jr. called our “inescapable network of mutuality, tied into a single garment of destiny.”

Storytelling

Storytelling is how we can communicate why I care, why we care, and why we must choose to act now: a story of self, a story of us, and a story of now. It is how we can speak the language of the heart. Storytelling can create the experience of values and can equip us with the motivational resources to respond to disruptions hopefully, rather than react to them fearfully. Individuals, community organizations, and nations all respond to stories.

In recent years, critics of democracy seem to be telling a more powerful story than democracy’s defenders. Why? Stories can evoke the experience of shared values. So, it is easier to tell a shared story rooted in the value of homogeneity: for example, racial homogeneity, gender homogeneity, or religious homogeneity. Any form of difference can be interpreted as a threat to the fundamental value. It can also be comforting to tell a story of real or imagined continuity from the past to the present: the ways of our fathers (usually), the comfortable good old days, and so on.

But democracy requires a commitment to equality, not to homogeneity. Democracy demands that we value each person equally, whatever their race, religion, gender, or class. This makes democracy about pluralism.

If the shared value is democracy, then difference is a positive value, not a threat. Democracy is about change, the future, and is enriched by diverse constituencies, generations, and classes. Democracy is also about broad-enough access to enough power to achieve change. Democracy's defenders must do the work of articulating the kinds of shared values that enable us to interpret diversity as an asset, rather than a liability.

Strategizing

Strategy is how we turn what we have (resources) into what we need (power) to get what we want (change). It too is something we know how to do. Any time you overslept, missed a bus, or had to take a sick child to the doctor, you strategized around the disruption. It is a verb, not a noun, something you do, rather than something you have. And just as we tell stories to access the emotional resources to respond to disruption, we strategize to access the cognitive resources to figure out how to respond to the disruption. We strategize by adapting to the obstacles that impede our progress to a valued goal, not by abandoning the goal but by reimagining how we can still get there.

Strategizing in the current context can be very challenging, given the disappearance of deliberative venues; the proliferation of narrow, issue-based mobilization; competition for funding; and an emphasis in many movements on tactical rather than strategic focus (e.g., how many calls did you make, rather than what difference did those calls make?). When we rely on a strategy that depends on access to outside money for organizing rather than on the resources of an inside constituency, we may get a win but fail to empower our people.

Unfortunately, the ease with which action can be digitally mobilized in reaction to motivating events often yields tactics devoid of strategy.¹⁰ We protest because we have to do something. This claim, while heartfelt, is more expressive than strategic. In moments like the massive reaction to the murder of George Floyd, for example, less-visible organizational infrastructure, like that of Black Lives Matter (BLM), may surface as sources of strategic leadership, or with enough time, such leadership may emerge from the protests themselves. Or it may not.

When it comes to organizing, the strategic challenge is how to counter the far greater resources of the status quo with greater resourcefulness—much as David, the young shepherd, defeated the powerful Goliath, master of

sword, shield, and helmet, with know-how learned protecting his flock from wolves and bears, a simple stone, a sling, some creativity, and a lot of courage. Good strategy is not a matter of genius, but it is a matter of who does the strategizing, with whom, what they bring to it, how committed they are to sustain it, and the process through which they create it.

Acting

The first time someone tells us they will show up and doesn't, we learn the difference between intention and action. In organizing, the purpose of action is to produce *observable change in the world by mobilizing individual resources and deploying them collectively*. An action might be a petition, a rally, a march, a public meeting, a picket line, a registered voter, a voter who voted, or something else. Close, specific, and sustained observation of the outcomes of one's actions, candid critical reflection on those outcomes, and identifying lessons for future action from that reflection, can, if systematic, turn one's own actions into a source of continued learning, growth, and development. We might think of it as "evidence-based organizing."

Whose resources are mobilized and by whom shapes who can deploy them and how—and vice versa. The most basic resources are money and time. Action today has come to rely far more on money than on time. These resources, in turn, are increasingly drawn from outside one's constituency than from within it.

This is a problem, as political scientist Sidney Verba argues, because time is far more widely distributed than money.¹¹ Relying on time, rather than money, strengthens democracy. Economist Albert Hirschman makes a similar distinction between moral resources that grow with use (commitment, skill, relationships) and economic resources (money, equipment, raw materials) that deplete with use.¹²

Similarly, resources contributed from within one's constituency—whether time or money—empower the constituency, whereas resources drawn from outside one's constituency—whether time or money—empower others. Perhaps the most serious challenges to democracy we face are the monetization of political mobilization and the transformation of much of civil society, including organizing, into the clients of philanthropic patronage.

Mobilizing and deploying people effectively requires motivation and commitment. We take our commitments seriously, which is why we avoid making them. Our motivation to commit is based more on the value we believe we can contribute than on the cost of the contribution. We invest more effort, initiative, and engagement in meaningful action for which we are responsible, and which is measurable as to the progress we are making than that for which we are not responsible.

Finally, action must be evaluated. When I was introduced to organizing I was told, “If you can’t count it, it didn’t happen.” When it comes to changing facts on the ground, they happen or they don’t happen. And that’s what we’re trying to do: create a different set of facts on the ground. And if we can’t see what we’re doing, how can you assess the effect, learn from the variation, and offer recognition or support to those who are doing it?

Structuring

Whenever two people share a commitment to meet at this place, on this date, and at this time, they are creating structure. They are building a possible future. That’s what structure means: it comes from the Latin *struere*, to build. And building, because it is about the future, is an expression of hope. We create structure when we share commitment to how we work together, learn together, decide together, and act together. By structuring, we can make the future less uncertain, use our time more purposefully, and coordinate our work together more reliably. Structure is how we can create the space for creativity, learning, and deliberation. The opposite of structure is not space but chaos. This is why we invest our structures with authority, transparency, and accountability. We need rules, procedures, and processes through which we can govern ourselves.

Democratic structuring requires creating accessible ways for people to make their voices heard, consistent spaces in which deliberation and decision-making can take place, and transparent processes through which the work can get done. It is also true, however, that even democratic structure can constrain more than enable when we fail to adapt to change. Because the world is always changing, it can be more useful to think of structure as a verb than a noun.

Perhaps the most critical element of structure is time: our most unrenowable resource. Recognizing this, paleontologist Stephen Jay Gould noted two forms of time: time as a cycle, the rhythm of continuity, and time as an arrow, the rhythm of change.¹³ Similarly, the Greeks distinguished between *chronos*, sequentially passing time, and *kairos*, the precise moment one must act. Campaigns embody time as an arrow: episodic, focused, and intense. Organizations embody time as a cycle: steady, deliberative, and substantial. Organizing involves both (Figure 1.7).

Campaigns are structured to achieve change by focusing attention, energy, and resources on the accomplishment of particular goals: for example, winning an election. They prioritize including as many people in the action as possible, but they are careful to bound decision-making and management to the qualified, however defined. They encourage diversity to facilitate creativity, innovation, and adaptation, but they require real unity in storytelling, campaign strategy, and effective action.

Organizations are structured to ensure continuity to grow in power, to develop expertise, and to secure sustained access to resources. They prioritize clear boundaries as to who is included as participants, managers, and decision-makers, but they also distribute responsibility, develop new leadership, and ensure accountability. And, like campaigns, they encourage diversity to facilitate creativity, innovation, and adaptation but require unity—or harmony—in storytelling, strategic focus, and effective action.

Organizing requires structuring continuity and change. Winning a single campaign—or even a series of campaigns—is a good thing. But rarely can one win shift the balance of power: wins are too easily reversed, promises not kept, and control reverts to the hands that held it before. Deep change requires sustained power to win it, keep it, and grow it. Individual campaign wins cannot be sustained in the absence of a vision of the organization we need to sustain those claims.

At the same time, maintaining power can too easily become a goal unto itself, supplanting the purpose for which the power was created in the first place. What was created to realize valued ends can become an end in itself. In the UFW, we were building a union, so each campaign, won or lost, could contribute the power built to that objective. Today, however, in many domains, after multiple campaign wins, power remains diffuse. The individuals who participated in the campaign may have changed, but that change hasn't been translated into sustained organization, much less structural change in politics, economics, or society.

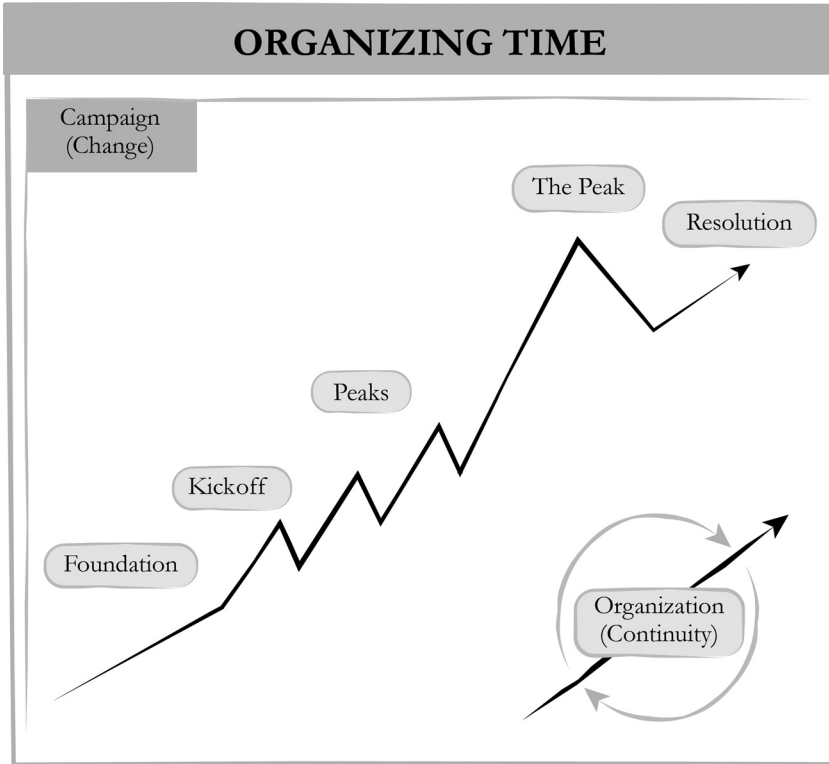


Figure 1.7 Organizing Time. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

Democracy requires structuring continuity and change. Effective democracy requires the means to guarantee that each citizen's voice counts equally, the deliberative processes to transform individual interests into common interests, and executive processes through which individual resources can be transformed into collective power. At the same time, democracy requires the means to hold power accountable; ways in which new people, ideas, and needs can effectively assert themselves. Democracy requires ways of building on the past without becoming imprisoned by it.

Developmental Leadership

In the seventh chapter, I focus on developing the capacity needed to combine these five key practices of purposive organizing: leadership. Recall that our

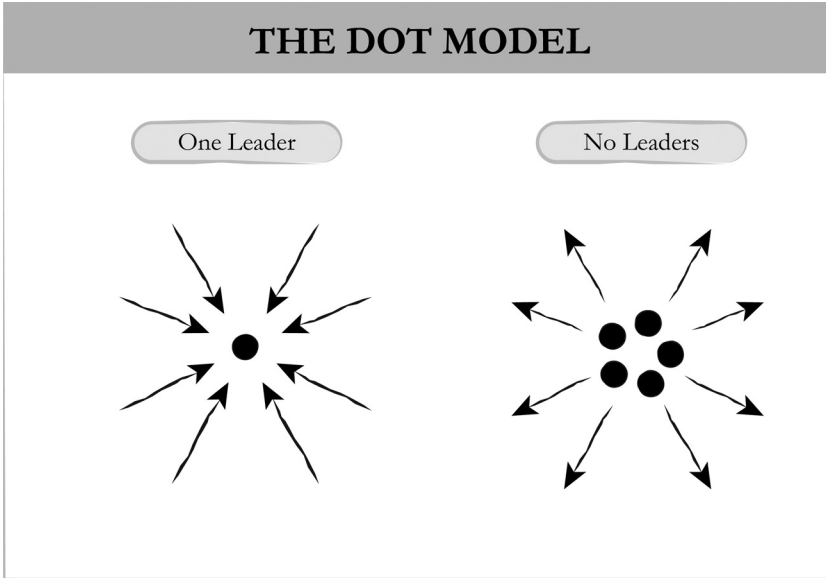


Figure 1.8 The Dot Model. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

definition of leadership requires accepting responsibility for enabling others to achieve shared purpose in the face of uncertainty. The practice of democracy requires leadership that can integrate our five practices in pursuit of a shared purpose or common goal. Recall, too, that we distinguish leadership from authority in that leadership enables rather than commands.¹⁴

The reality is that no one person can really do all this, yet many think they can. Some people react by abandoning the idea of authoritative leadership entirely for a structure in which everyone leads. Neither structure lends itself to effective organizing (Figure 1.8).

Our first move, then, should be to focus on building “real” leadership teams, as opposed to single leaders. This too requires learning the craft of how to make it work. Our second move is to focus on how a leadership team can achieve scale by developing the leadership of others, an approach some people call a snowflake model of leadership: each team member reaches out to form their own team, and each member of that team reaches out to develop their own, and so forth (Figure 1.9).¹⁵ We also tackle how we can identify leadership or potential leadership, how we can recruit them to lead, and how we can continue to support their development.

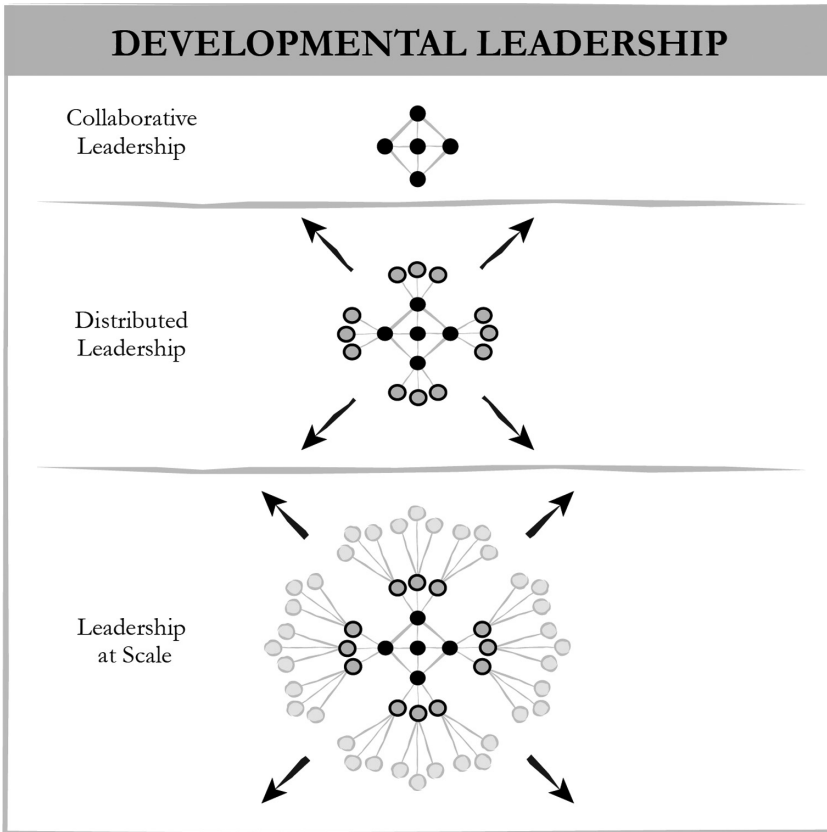


Figure 1.9 Developmental Leadership. Source: Steve Downer of the Difference

“The Promise of Democratic Practice”

The central argument of this book is simple: Redeeming the democratic promise from the clutches of oligarchic rule requires leadership, organizing, and action. It requires restoring people to the center of political processes, turning people’s resources into the power they need to achieve real change in their day-to-day lives. This is a book about people, power, and change.

As stated above, leadership is the act of accepting responsibility (*self*) for enabling others to achieve shared purpose (*us*) under conditions of uncertainty (*now*). Organizers develop leadership, build community with that leadership, and create power from the resources of that community.

We can organize to do more than fix an immediate problem. We can enable people with the problem to build the power they need to challenge structures

responsible for their problem in the first place. This requires ongoing leadership development, motivation, and learning. We do not have to be content with fixing bugs in the system. If we organize, we can change the features of the system itself.

The organizing craft is at the heart of successful community organizations, civic associations, advocacy groups, trade unions, social movements, and democracy itself. Social movements have driven transformational politics in America via their influence on the parties, policy, and political culture more generally.¹⁶ And organizing can play a role in electoral politics, despite the political marketing business, as demonstrated by the 2008 Obama campaign or the more recent electoral insurgencies at local, state, and national levels.

Organizing brings us out of our narrow self-interests into broader understandings of the common good. It can create experiences of empathy that facilitate solidarity and enable us to learn basic skills of democratic self-government, just as Tocqueville said it would.

We need a better understanding of how the democratic promise is being betrayed, but perhaps even more important is what we decide to do about it. We must confront not only the immediate crisis of electoral politics, but also the lack of capacity for collective action on which our entire civic culture depends. Our challenge is to overcome the asymmetrical resources, the fractured electorate, the unequal voices, and the sclerotic political institutions that have enabled a recalcitrant minority to stifle the voices of our newly emergent majority—allowing the past to trump the future.

This is not a book of answers. Rather, it is an invitation to accept responsibility for joining with one another to forge answers. We must learn from the past as well as the present; from our failures as well as our successes; and we must learn to sustaining the effort in ongoing, resilient, and audaciously adaptive ways.

* * *

When Bob Moses called us into that auditorium in 1964, he was asking us to decide who we were going to be in the world. This book asks a similar question of its readership. This is a book about agency: my own, that of others with whom I have worked, and of those whom I have yet to meet but who find themselves asking questions of what they are called to do, what their community is called to do, and what they are must do now. It is another way of asking Hillel's three questions:

If I am not for myself, who will be for me?

If I am for myself alone, what am I?

If not now, when?